



T-storm 89/75 • Tomorrow: Partly sunny 88/76 **B18**

Democracy Dies in Darkness

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## Europe’s plea: Do not trade Kyiv’s land

Leaders work to shape Trump’s thinking ahead of summit with Putin

BY ELLEN FRANCIS

BRUSSELS — European leaders on Wednesday implored President Donald Trump to keep one key point in mind when he meets with Russian President Vladimir Putin in Alaska: The United States cannot — must not — negotiate away Ukrainian territory, especially for nothing in return.

As Trump floats “land swaps,” Kyiv’s European backers have rejected a Russian proposal to trade Ukrainian land for an undefined truce.

European leaders pressed their priorities in a call with Trump organized by German Chancellor Friedrich Merz on Wednesday. They spoke first with Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky, who traveled to Berlin, and then Trump joined. The call was intended to shape Trump’s thinking before the Alaska summit on Friday, with the anxious Europeans well aware that Trump in the past has seemed to fall under Putin’s spell.

European leaders emerged heralding the conversation as unifying.

French President Emmanuel Macron said Trump was “very clear” on Wednesday that he wants to obtain a ceasefire, and he said that Trump agreed that Ukraine should be involved in any talks on territory.

Macron said Trump also assured the Europeans that he would later seek a trilateral summit with Putin and Zelensky.

Trump confirmed on Wednesday that he hoped to arrange a three-way meeting after Alaska, and he praised the call with the Europeans and Zelensky. “I would rate it a 10, you know, very, very friendly,” Trump said during a visit to the Kennedy Center. Trump also repeated his claim that the war would not have happened if he had been in office. “This isn’t my war,” he said. “It is what it is, and I’m here to fix it.”

But he strongly downplayed expectations that the meeting with Putin would yield an immediate breakthrough.

SEE SUMMIT ON A9

**Bargaining chip:** Ukraine seized Russian territory, but it’s gone. **A8**

## Mothers flee workforce, erasing pandemic gains

Strict return-to-office mandates, layoffs have taken a toll

BY ABHA BHATTARAI

Working mothers, who helped drive much of the job market’s post-pandemic comeback, are leaving the workforce in large numbers this year.

The share of working mothers ages 25 to 44 with young children has fallen nearly every month this year, dropping by nearly 3 percentage points between January and June, to the lowest level in more than three years, according to an analysis of federal data by Misty Heggeness, a professor at the University of Kansas and

former principal economist at the Census Bureau.

The drop has been enough to wipe out many of the gains made by working mothers after the pandemic, when remote work arrangements and flexible schedules lured many back to the labor force.

But the reversal of many of those policies — with major corporations and government agencies now requiring employees to be back in the office five days a week — has had the opposite effect, Heggeness said. Sweeping federal layoffs have also been a setback for women and other caregivers, who have long relied on the government for stable and flexible employment.

“It’s become harder for women,

SEE WORKFORCE ON A14



## Inside 13-year search for Tice, the journalist captured in Syria

BY SOUAD MEKHENNET, ELLEN NAKASHIMA, JOANNA SLATER AND AARON SCHAEFFER

DAMASCUS, SYRIA — The American journalist was held in a makeshift jail controlled by a top Syrian security official, a row of small cells with metal doors off a street in western Damascus. The prisoner had a request for his captors: Could he have soap, a towel, something to read?

Days later, Austin Tice made a desperate bid for freedom. He squeezed his body through the window of his cell and threw the towel

over an exterior wall topped with shards of glass.

A reporter known for his courage in covering Syria’s brutal civil war and a Marine veteran who fought in Iraq and Afghanistan, Tice, 31, had been detained in mid-August 2012 near the Syrian capital.

His escape that October was short-lived, according to U.S. and Syrian officials, as well as Tice’s interrogator. Tice’s captors put out an alert to security services across Damascus and swiftly recaptured him. From there, he would disappear into one of the world’s most secretive and repressive regimes.

Ever since, Tice’s family and three American presidents have tried to find him, an agonizing endeavor where at times the only constant appeared to be the swirl of unconfirmed information and the obduracy of Syrian President Bashar al-Assad.

Despite intensive efforts to secure Tice’s release or confirm his status, the truth about his fate remains elusive, making his case one of the most difficult U.S. officials say they have ever encountered.

When the Assad regime crumbled in December 2024 after a whirlwind rebel advance, Tice’s family saw an

SEE TICE ON A10

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## With Trump as host, center to honor Kiss, Stallone

BY TRAVIS M. ANDREWS AND JANAY KINGSBERRY

President Donald Trump announced the recipients of the 48th Kennedy Center Honors on Wednesday — the first class of honorees since he took over the arts complex this year — and a major change to the ceremony: He’ll be the host.

Speaking from the center’s Hall of Nations, Trump revealed the 2025 honorees by unveiling five portraits draped in velvet.

The group: glam metal band Kiss, Broadway and West End star Michael Crawford, country music legend George Strait, actor Sylvester Stallone and singer Gloria Gaynor.

Actor Tom Cruise was offered the honors but declined because of scheduling conflicts, according to several current and former Kennedy Center employees who spoke on the condition of anonymity because they were not authorized to publicly discuss event plans. A spokesperson for

Cruise declined to comment.

Before naming the honorees, Trump said he always wanted the award himself but “was never able to get one.”

“I waited and waited and waited, and I said, ‘The hell with it, I’ll become chairman and I’ll give myself an honor,’” he said, drawing chuckles from a crowd that included Kennedy Center President Richard Grenell, Sen. Lindsey Graham (R-South Carolina) and members of the White House staff. “. . . Next year, we’ll honor

Trump, okay?”

The choices may surprise some Trump critics. When Trump took over the Kennedy Center, an overworked joke circulated on social media. Here is political analyst Larry Sabato’s version: “Can you imagine forthcoming Kennedy Center Honors for Lee Greenwood, The Village People, and Kid Rock? Inevitable with

SEE KENNEDY CENTER ON A2

**White House ballroom:** Trump’s vision reflects a new Gilded Age. **B1**

## Troops, agents surge into D.C.

TRUMP SEEKS 24/7, LONG-TERM MISSION

Bowser rebukes rhetoric, welcomes help on crime

BY MEAGAN FLYNN, JENNY GATHRIGHT, EMMA UBER AND ERIN COX

A split screen emerged in the first 48 hours of President Donald Trump’s deployment of federal law enforcement and the National Guard onto D.C. streets: rhetoric from the president painting the city as a crime-addled wasteland, which D.C. Mayor Muriel E. Bowser (D) condemned, and, on the ground, a surge in federal resources bolstering D.C. police — which she and the police chief welcomed.

The impact of Trump’s federal actions came into view Tuesday night, with National Guard troops on the ground and agents from numerous federal agencies roaming D.C. streets from the National Mall to busy corridors in Columbia Heights. The White House said the overnight operation would soon become a 24/7 affair, with a significantly greater National Guard presence — and Trump said he intended to ask Congress to extend the emergency allowing him to federalize D.C. police beyond 30 days.

“We’re going to be asking for

SEE TRUMP ON A4

**Few options:** Homeless begin to see the effects of crackdown. **B13**

**Residents react:** Many disapprove of actions being taken in D.C. **B15**

## Federal effort to tackle D.C. crime in 1989 shows pitfalls

BY SPENCER S. HSU AND PAUL DUGGAN

In 1989, before the new millennium brought economic rebirth to the nation’s capital, large swaths of Washington actually resembled the hellish crimescape that President Donald Trump contends the city has become today.

The crack epidemic was raging. Gangs of drug dealers engaged in murderous competition. The annual homicide toll nearly surpassed 500, nearly five times last year’s total, at a time when the city had about 100,000 fewer residents. The poverty-riven city was mired in fiscal and social chaos — and on the cusp of bankruptcy. The rampant “bloodshed, bedlam and squalor” that Trump conjured to describe the city this week was a stark reality.

Back then, in a now largely forgotten intervention in the annals of on-again, off-again federal control of the nation’s capital, it wasn’t the White House that led the effort, as Trump did Monday. It was Congress. And the results were disastrous. Just a few years later, Congress intervened again with much better results — establishing a financial control board that helped turn around the city’s dire finances.

Today, criminal laws relaxed following the murder of George

SEE D.C. ON A4



LEXI PARRA/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Emily Santoni left her high-paying job this year to stay home with her children, who are 1 and 3.

### IN THE NEWS

**Strange supernova** Astronomers believe one of the universe’s oddest blasts ever observed was caused by a star exploding while getting ripped apart by a black hole. **A7**

**Loudoun holds firm** The school board votes to maintain its gender policies despite an order from the Education Department. **B13**

**THE NATION**  
**An appeals court** ruled that the Trump administration can freeze billions in foreign aid. **A2**  
**The fight** over midterm maps favors the GOP — and could help the party stay in power. **A3**

**THE WORLD**  
**The Vances** are the latest affluent Americans to fall under the spell of the Cotswolds. **A6**  
**Germany’s chancellor** is facing a revolt in his party over halted arms exports to Israel. **A9**

**THE ECONOMY**  
**President Trump’s** deal that cuts the government in on AI chip sales to China sets a new pay-to-play precedent for U.S. exporters. **A13**  
**Labor unions** are partnering with state lawmakers to place AI guardrails as employers deploy it at work. **A14**

**STYLE**  
**An animated film trio** became the first K-pop girl group in Billboard history to claim the No. 1 spot. **B1**  
**SPORTS**  
**To play or not to play?** Barry Svrluga on the dilemma facing Keegan Bradley, captain of the U.S. Ryder Cup team. **B7**

**THE REGION**  
**A union** that represents nearly 11,000 Virginia law enforcement officers has endorsed Democrat Abigail Spanberger in the governor’s race. **B13**

**LOCAL LIVING**  
**Parents say** they want a return, but modern norms are scaring away the villagers.

BUSINESS NEWS.....A13  
COMICS.....B4  
OBITUARIES.....B17  
OPINION PAGES.....A15  
TELEVISION.....B6  
WORLD NEWS.....A6

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